

dia and will continue to do so for the next two decades at least,” Sanjay Lazar, CEO, Avialaz Consultants, tells *Business Today*.

BIG DREAMS

A recent report by Knight Frank said that India’s air passenger traffic is projected to increase nearly 50%, from 412 million in the last financial year (FY25) to 600 million by FY30. The government plans to add another 50 airports by the end of this decade. The airlines, on their part, have an order book of around 1,500 aircraft, a source of ready demand for the new airport infrastructure. These airports are projected to attract an investment of ₹1 lakh crore by 2030.

The aim of having a world-class airport infrastructure is to position India as a global aviation hub on the lines of Dubai, Singapore and Doha. However, experts point out that despite the operationalisation of NMIA and NIA, there is a list of operational infrastructure, along with policy and regulatory levers, that requires attention if India is to become a global aviation hub.

Union Civil Aviation Minister K. Rammohan Naidu recently said the government is in the process of achieving smooth passenger transfers between domestic and international flights, which is a key step towards making India a global aviation hub. “On the ground, the real challenge is to ensure smooth transfers across all combinations: domestic to domestic, international to domestic, domestic to international, and international to international. Once we address these challenges, our airports will be on a par with the best in the world,” he said.

The ministry is devising a system where passengers travelling abroad from Delhi or Mumbai can complete immigration checks at selected origin airports.

NIA, likely to be operational by December, will have a capacity of 12 million passengers per annum (mmpa) in the first phase, going up to 70 mmpa in the fourth phase. NMIA will have a capacity of 20 mmpa; it will reach 90 mmpa in the final phase.

However, the passenger capacity of both the new airports is less than that of large global airports such as Atlanta, Dubai, Dallas and Heathrow, which handle

more than 80 million passengers per annum, says Suprio Banerjee, Vice President and Co-Group Head, Corporate Ratings, ICRA Ltd. The existing IGI airport in Delhi had got 79.3 million passengers in the year ended March 31, 2025, while Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport (CSMIA) in Mumbai handled 55.2 million passengers.

“The current operational scale of Navi Mumbai and Noida airports would be lower than these airports, but given their ultimate expansion plans, the new airports are likely to catch up in scale over the next 5-10 years,” Banerjee tells *BT*.

The NMIA, along with CSMIA, will form a unique dual-airport system within MMR. Both these airports are operated by Gautam Adani-owned Adani Group, which is the largest operator of airports under the public-private partnership (PPP) model in India. It operates Lucknow, Thiruvananthapuram, Jaipur and Lucknow, among others. GMR

runs Delhi, Hyderabad and Goa, while state and private players run Cochin, Bengaluru and Kannur airports.

NMIA is among the first airports in India that will offer passengers and stakeholders an end-to-end digital experience from the first day of commercial operations. Travellers will experience a seamless, technology-led journey designed to deliver speed, comfort, and efficiency, says the company.

Adani Airport Holdings Ltd (AAHL) has part-

